

John Lystad

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EXPERIENCE

U.S. Mission to the United Nations, Department of State

Jun. 2026 – Present

Military Staff Advisor | Jun. 2026 – Present

New York City, NY

- Served as a Department of Defense attaché to the U.S. Mission to the United Nations, advising the Ambassador on military, humanitarian, social, and development policy approaches before ECOSOC and relevant UN bodies.
- Integrated quantitative and statistical research methods into multilateral policy analysis, supporting U.S. efforts in international development, humanitarian assistance, multinational peacekeeping, and AI governance.
- Translated large, fragmented UN and international development data into concise, actionable findings for senior leadership to support U.S. diplomatic strategic and ambassadorial decision-making.

United States Army

Nov. 2021 – Present

Officer Commissioning Candidate | Jul. 2025 – Present

New York City, NY

- Integrated prior active-duty enlisted experience into officer development, peer mentorship, and practical problem-solving during team-based exercises.
- Received extensive training through a structured leadership program emphasizing decision-making, planning, ethics, and team performance under time constraints under stressful conditions.

Infantry Squad Leader | Mar. 2023 – Jul. 2025

Joint Base Elmendorf Richardson, AK

- Served as a Squad Leader in an Airborne Infantry Battalion prepared for rapid deployment in support of worldwide combat and contingency operations within 18 hours of notification.
- Developed the highest rated Indirect Fire Infantry Squad in the 11th Airborne Division and maintained a high level of discipline, physical readiness, morale, and personal development, resulting in the squad being selected to represent the division in the 2024 International Best Mortar Competition.
- Guided and coached subordinates in essential military tasks and key leadership abilities, effectively preparing more than 25 platoon members for success at advanced training opportunities.
- Took initiative to develop innovative Standard Operating Procedures in order to enable consistent communications capabilities for the battalion's mortars, scouts, snipers, medics and headquarters elements.
 - Managed sensitive, often highly classified, property valued in excess of \$75 million without incident.

Indirect Fire Infantryman | Nov. 2021 – Mar. 2023

Joint Base Elmendorf Richardson, AK

- Selected for and successfully completed a wide variety of specialized training, including: Airborne School, the Cold Weather Leadership Course, the Military Mountaineering Course, the Infantry Mortar Leader Course, and the Expert Infantryman Badge qualification.
- Participated in the inter-agency Arctic Working Group (AWG) to develop innovative solutions for indirect fire military operations in extreme cold weather environments.

National Consortium for the Research of Terrorism and Responses to Terrorism **May 2021 – Feb. 2022**

Researcher, Weapons and Tactics Team | May 2021 – Feb. 2022

Remote

- Conducted open-source research on terrorist and extremist incidents, organizations, weapon types, and attack tactics to support structured analysis of violence patterns and operational behavior.
- Analyzed trends in weapon selection, tactical adaptation, and attack outcomes across time, geography, and ideological categories for use in research products and briefings.
- Collaborated with multidisciplinary research teams on projects related to terrorism, targeted violence, and counter-terrorism, contributing data support, written analysis, and methodological consistency.

EDUCATION

New York University
M.S., Applied Statistics for Social Science Research (AS3R)
GPA: 3.6/4.0

Aug. 2025 – May 2027
New York City, NY

American Military University
Non-Degree Program
GPA: 3.5 / 4.0

Jan. 2024 – Jul. 2025
Remote

Florida State University
B.A., International Affairs | B.S., Sociology | Minor, Middle East Studies
GPA: 3.98 / 4.0

Aug. 2018 – May 2022
Tallahassee, FL

PROJECTS

“The Caliphate’s Target Map: Ethnosectarian Composition and Insurgent Violence in Iraq”. Published May 2026.

Examined whether Islamic State attack patterns in Iraq aligned with its sectarian ideology by linking insurgent violence to district-level ethnosectarian composition, population-weighted geography, and target-type modeling. Identified concentrated attack activity in Sunni and religiously fractionalized areas, alongside elevated civilian targeting in non-Sunni districts.

“Estimating Lethality Under Missing Casualty Data: Suicide Attacks in Islamic State-Linked Terrorism”. Unpublished May 2026.

Analyzed missing casualty data and perpetrator-attribution bias in terrorism event datasets, demonstrating how incomplete open-source records can alter statistical conclusions about attack lethality and terrorist tactical behavior.

“Vanguards of Terror: The Strategic and Tactical Orientation and Cohesion of the Islamic State Insurgency: 1999-2019”. Published May 2022.

Compared the tactical and strategic cohesion of wilayat within the Islamic State and its Associated Movement, investigating the inner workings of the Islamic State and demonstrating that the operational behavior of wilayat within the Islamic State are not uniform.

“The Effects of Climate Change on the Development of Terrorist Networks in the Middle East and North Africa”. Published Dec. 2020.

Analyzed how projected changes in temperature, precipitation, evaporation, and heat stress could intensify resource scarcity, weaken governance, and create conditions exploitable by terrorist organizations in the Middle East. Used NASA Global Climate Model scenario comparisons to connect environmental change with recruitment dynamics and regional instability.

CERTIFICATIONS, SKILLS & INTERESTS

- **Certifications:** American Avalanche Association Rescue Certification; Level 1 Mountaineering Certification
- **Languages:** English (Native); Arabic (Intermediate Working)
- **Technologies:** R; SQL; Stan; Python; QGIS; Open-Source Intelligence
- **Skills:** Leadership; Interdisciplinary Research; Bayesian Inference; Data Visualization
- **Interests:** Mountaineering; International Studies; Open-Source Community